about what might have happened, what could easily have happened, and what nearly did happen.

One of the more intriguing of Robert McNamara's recollections concerns the preparations of the Kennedy administration to fight a nuclear war. When asked in 1987 what would have happened if war had broken out, he replied:

> This is a very important question. Important mainly because I have no idea what the answer is. I thought about it and I had discussed it with the President. If we had been attacked with nuclear weapons I am certain that the President would have responded with one, or two, or maybe ten – something like that. Neither he nor I thought that we should respond at all, though, until we could determine what had happened. Now I know the SIOP [Single Integrated Operational Plan] called for a massive response and I also recall that the President said in his speech announcing the quarantine that we'd respond massively. No way would we have done that. But … during the missile crisis we never even talked about it. Sure, it was a low probability, as I've said. But if some damn Soviet second lieutenant had launched a missile and it destroyed, say Atlanta, would we have then gone to an all-out nuclear war? I hope not. But we never discussed it. We should have, but we didn't.[4]

If Kennedy's Defense Secretary doesn't provide an answer to this question, how can we? Yet, as he himself demonstrated over many decades, it is surely essential to search for answers and seek lessons for the future. After many years of studying, debating, and reflecting on the crisis, Robert McNamara concluded: 'We can do little or nothing about human fallibility. To prevent the destruction of nations, we have no choice but to abolish nuclear weapons as swiftly and safely as possible.'[5] Whether this is the correct conclusion is for the reader to decide.

Armageddon is a term often used in discussion about nuclear war. It emanates from the Book of Revelation in the New Testament and refers to the battle between good and evil that presages the second coming of the